

BIBLICAL HERMENEUTICS

COURSE PREVIEW

Selected pages from the complete 40-lesson self-paced course
343-page student manual • foundational and advanced instruction • practical tools

Inside this 24-page preview

- Course orientation and roadmap
- A complete foundational lesson
- A complete advanced lesson
- Selected diagnostic and evidence tools

Preview note: Original manual page numbers are preserved and therefore jump between selected sections. No pages are missing from the purchased course.

ZAY-MARIE PRESS

BIBLICAL HERMENEUTICS

A 40-Lesson Course in Responsible Scriptural Interpretation

Observation • Context • Genre • Canonical Correlation • Right Division • Integrated Exegesis

STUDENT COURSE MANUAL

Zay-Marie Press Biblical Hermeneutics is a forty-lesson curriculum designed to train readers to interpret Scripture by disciplined attention to the biblical text, its context, literary form, canonical relationships, revelatory development, programmatic authority, and legitimate application.

The curriculum follows an evidence-first method. Interpretive frameworks may guide appropriate questions, but Scripture must supply the evidence and govern the conclusion.

Publisher: Zay-Marie Press

Course format: one complete self-paced course—40 lessons in ten parts, followed by four integrated student tools

COURSE INTRODUCTION

Purpose of the Course

Biblical hermeneutics is the disciplined work of understanding what Scripture communicates. This course develops that discipline cumulatively. Readers begin with interpretive posture and observation, move through context, language, historical setting, literary form, canonical correlation, and theological synthesis, and then apply those controls to right division, programmatic interpretation, Acts chronology, responsible application, diagnostic hermeneutics, and integrated exegesis.

The goal is not merely to give readers a set of interpretive rules. The goal is to train a repeatable method by which conclusions can be examined, tested, corrected, and defended from Scripture.

Course Method

The course repeatedly follows a governing movement: OBSERVE → INTERPRET → CLASSIFY → SYNTHESIZE → APPLY. Later lessons reduce scaffolding so that readers increasingly select and coordinate the necessary interpretive controls for themselves.

The course also maintains a consistent evidentiary discipline: meaning before application; context before conclusion; textual evidence before theological assumption; discovery before synthesis; and programmatic classification only after the relevant Scriptural evidence has been established.

How to Use the Lessons

Work through the lessons in sequence. Later competencies assume the controls established earlier. Read every assigned biblical passage in its surrounding context, complete the exercises before consulting secondary explanations when instructed, and preserve a written evidence record so that conclusions can be traced back to Scripture.

Because this is a self-paced course, do not treat lesson completion as mere reading progress. A Part is complete only when its four lessons, exercises, evidence records, and Completion Check have been completed. Preserve all work for the guided integrated exegesis and final capstone.

Each lesson uses a recurring instructional architecture: Lesson Purpose, Biblical Foundation, Teaching Development, governing Hermeneutical Principle or safeguards, guided or independent practice appropriate to the lesson's stage, a competency-oriented Lesson Summary, and a Progressive Glossary.

Course Progression

Parts I–II establish interpretive posture and observation. Parts III–IV develop contextual, linguistic, historical, and authorial-intent controls. Parts V–VII develop literary-form and canonical interpretation. Parts VIII–IX develop doctrine, biblical assignment, progressive revelation, model testing, comparative interpretation, and chronological analysis. Part X develops responsible application, diagnosis, integrated exegesis, and independent mastery.

COURSE ROADMAP

Use this roadmap to track the cumulative movement of the course. Each Part adds controls that remain active in later work. The Completion Checks require four levels of performance: KNOW, IDENTIFY, DIAGNOSE, and PERFORM.

COURSE NEUTRALITY CONTROL: No named theological model functions as an assumed premise, required conclusion, or grading criterion. Students are evaluated by textual accuracy, contextual reasoning, evidentiary discipline, fair treatment of alternatives, and responsible application.

GOVERNING SEQUENCE: MEANING FIRST. ASSIGNMENT SECOND. APPLICATION THIRD.

Part	Lessons	Focus	Competency Developed	Milestone Output
I	1–4	Foundations	Interpret under Scripture’s authority; distinguish exegesis, meaning, assignment, application, and presupposition.	Completion Check: establish a controlled interpretive posture.
II	5–8	Observation	Observe words, repetition, contrast, relationships, structure, and flow before drawing conclusions.	Completion Check: produce an evidence-first observation record.
III	9–12	Contextual Interpretation	Use immediate and literary context, communication setting, history, grammar, and syntax to constrain meaning.	Completion Check: defend a contextual interpretation.
IV	13–16	Language and Authorial Intent	Perform responsible word study, use tools carefully, interpret figures, and establish communicated intent.	Completion Check: integrate linguistic evidence without overclaiming.
V	17–20	Literary Interpretation	Read genre, narrative, law, covenant instruction, poetry, and psalms according to their forms.	Completion Check: produce a form-sensitive interpretation.
VI	21–24	Literary Forms and Canonical Correlation	Interpret wisdom, Gospels, parables, and epistles while following their distinctive communicative structures.	Completion Check: trace the passage’s controlling literary logic.
VII	25–28	Prophecy and Canonical Development	Interpret prophecy and apocalyptic literature; correlate Scripture; preserve progressive revelation; classify correspondences.	Completion Check: construct a restrained canonical synthesis.

Part	Lessons	Focus	Competency Developed	Milestone Output
VIII	29–32	Doctrine and Biblical Assignment	Build doctrine from interpreted passages; use right division; identify presuppositions and test interpretive systems.	Completion Check: distinguish evidence, inference, model, and unresolved questions.
IX	33–36	Testing Interpretive Systems	Test continuity and discontinuity, evaluate models, compare interpretations fairly, and analyze narrative chronology.	Completion Check: defend an evidence-based conclusion while representing alternatives fairly.
X	37–40	Application and Independent Mastery	Classify application, diagnose errors, complete guided exegesis, and perform independent interpretation.	Completion Check: complete and defend the capstone exegesis.

Recommended pacing: complete one lesson at a time; maintain the evidence ledger throughout; pause after each four-lesson Part to complete its checkpoint; retain every completed checkpoint and ledger entry for the guided exegesis and capstone.

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The lessons are presented sequentially. Part headings mark the major stages of the course. The student tools are cumulative and should be retained as part of the student's completed course record.

LESSON 1 — WHAT BIBLICAL HERMENEUTICS IS — Why Interpretation Matters

Lesson Purpose

This lesson equips students to understand biblical hermeneutics as the disciplined interpretation of Scripture under Scripture's own authority. The problem matters because every reader interprets, and unexamined assumptions can quietly replace the meaning communicated through the biblical text.

Students will distinguish hermeneutics from exegesis and eisegesis, relate observation, interpretation, and application, and recognize why context, speaker, audience, literary form, and interpretive humility are necessary controls. They will also learn the foundational sequence: Meaning first. Assignment second. Application third.

By the end of the lesson, students will be able to define biblical hermeneutics, distinguish responsible interpretation from imposed meaning, explain why interpretation is unavoidable, and identify the basic controls that keep the interpreter accountable to Scripture. These competencies establish the posture and vocabulary required for every later lesson.

Biblical Foundation

Several passages provide an appropriate foundation for understanding the interpretive task.

Nehemiah 8:8 describes the public reading of God's Law together with the giving of understanding so that the people could comprehend what was read.

Luke 24:27 records Christ explaining from Moses and the Prophets the things concerning Himself.

Acts 8:30–35 presents Philip asking the Ethiopian official whether he understands what he is reading and then explaining the passage from Isaiah.

2 Timothy 2:15 emphasizes the responsibility to handle the Word of truth correctly.

Together these passages demonstrate an important reality: reading the words of Scripture and understanding those words are related, but they are not identical activities.

Scripture communicates meaning. The responsibility of the interpreter is to understand that meaning faithfully.

1. God Has Communicated Through Scripture

Biblical interpretation begins with communication.

The Bible is not a collection of meaningless religious expressions waiting for readers to supply their own significance. God has communicated through human language. Scripture contains words arranged into sentences, paragraphs, arguments, narratives, poems, prophecies, letters, commands, promises, explanations, and other recognizable forms of communication.

Because God has communicated, interpretation begins with the conviction that the biblical text possesses meaning.

The interpreter's responsibility is not to create that meaning. It is to discover it.

If meaning is created by the reader, then the text can ultimately mean whatever a reader wishes it to mean. Biblical interpretation proceeds differently. It asks: What has actually been communicated here?

That question places the interpreter under the authority of Scripture. Our experiences, traditions, theological systems, assumptions, and personal preferences may influence the questions we bring to the Bible, but none of them possesses the authority to determine in advance what a biblical passage must mean. The text must be allowed to speak.

2. What Is Biblical Hermeneutics?

Biblical hermeneutics is the disciplined study and application of principles used to understand the meaning of Scripture faithfully.

Hermeneutics asks what the text says, what its words mean in context, who is speaking or writing, who is addressed, what historical circumstances surround the passage, what literary form is used, what argument or purpose is developed, how the passage relates to larger biblical context, what conclusions the text establishes, and what legitimate application follows.

These questions are not substitutes for Scripture. They are tools for paying closer attention to Scripture. Good hermeneutics continually directs the interpreter back to the text.

3. Hermeneutics and Exegesis

Hermeneutics concerns the principles and methods by which Scripture is interpreted. Exegesis is the actual examination of a particular biblical passage using those principles.

Hermeneutics supplies the interpretive controls. Exegesis applies those controls to the text.

This course will teach both. Knowing that context matters is not enough. The interpreter must learn how to examine context.

4. Exegesis and Eisegesis

Exegesis seeks to draw meaning from the biblical text. Eisegesis reads meaning into the text that the text itself does not establish.

A true doctrine can still be supported by a wrongly interpreted verse. The question cannot merely be, Is this conclusion true? We must also ask, Does this passage actually teach this conclusion?

Sound interpretation examines the evidence of the passage and allows that evidence to govern the conclusion.

5. Meaning Comes Before Application

Readers naturally want to know how Scripture applies to their lives. That desire is appropriate, but legitimate application must come after interpretation, not before it.

Before asking, What does this mean for me? we must first ask, What does this passage mean?

A biblical passage was communicated within an actual setting. Someone spoke or wrote. Someone was addressed. Words were chosen. Circumstances existed. A purpose was being accomplished.

This also means that Scriptural profitability and direct address are not identical. A passage may teach us important truth without every command, covenant, promise, ordinance, commission, or historical practice recorded in that passage being directly assigned to every reader.

Meaning before application.

6. Observation, Interpretation, and Application

Observation asks: What does the text say? Interpretation asks: What does the text mean?

Application asks: How should the truth that has been established affect understanding, belief, conduct, worship, ministry, or life?

OBSERVATION → INTERPRETATION → APPLICATION

Poor interpretation frequently occurs because readers move from a few noticed words directly to application. Disciplined interpretation slows the process down: first see what is there, then determine what it means, then consider its legitimate implications.

7. Context Is Not Optional

Words do not normally communicate in isolation. A dictionary may tell us what a word can mean. The context helps determine what it does mean in a particular statement.

A verse belongs to a paragraph. A paragraph belongs to a larger argument or narrative. That material belongs to a biblical book written within particular circumstances and ultimately within the larger canon of Scripture.

READ AROUND THE VERSE. Context does not merely add background information. It frequently determines meaning.

8. Speaker and Audience Matter

Interpretation requires attention to who speaks and who is addressed. The Bible records many speakers, and the fact that words appear in Scripture guarantees that the record is inspired; it does not mean that every recorded speaker's statement is itself a truthful doctrinal declaration.

A command given to a particular person must first be understood as a command given to that person. A national instruction must first be understood in relation to the nation addressed. A communication directed to a particular congregation must be interpreted within the circumstances in which it was given.

IDENTIFY THE SPEAKER AND THE AUDIENCE BEFORE ASSUMING THE APPLICATION.

9. Description Is Not Automatically Prescription

Scripture often tells us what happened. That does not automatically mean Scripture is commanding us to repeat everything that happened.

Description is what the text reports; prescription is what the text commands or establishes as an obligation.

WHAT SCRIPTURE RECORDS PEOPLE DOING IS NOT AUTOMATICALLY WHAT SCRIPTURE COMMANDS EVERY READER TO DO.

10. Interpretation Requires Humility

Responsible hermeneutics requires more than technique. It requires humility.

Every interpreter brings assumptions to Scripture. The danger is not merely having presuppositions. The greater danger is refusing to allow Scripture to challenge them.

A disciplined interpreter must be willing to say: I may have understood this incorrectly. The goal is to understand faithfully what God has communicated.

Hermeneutical Principle

THE INTERPRETER'S TASK IS TO DISCOVER THE MEANING COMMUNICATED BY SCRIPTURE, NOT TO CREATE OR IMPOSE MEANING UPON IT.

Interpretive Safeguards

MEANING BEFORE APPLICATION

CONTEXT BEFORE CONCLUSION

TEXTUAL EVIDENCE BEFORE THEOLOGICAL ASSUMPTION

DESCRIPTION DOES NOT EQUAL AUTOMATIC PRESCRIPTION

Guided Practice Exercise

Read Acts 8:26–35 carefully. Do not consult a commentary yet. This first exercise is intentionally guided.

Step 1 — Observe

Write down what you can identify directly from the passage: the principal people, what the Ethiopian official is doing, what passage he is reading, what Philip asks, what the official asks, and what Philip does.

Step 2 — Examine the Immediate Context

Read beyond a single verse. What events bring Philip and the official together? What information does Luke provide about the situation?

Step 3 — Identify Speaker and Audience

Who speaks in the conversation? Who is addressed? When Isaiah is quoted, who originally wrote the words being read?

Step 4 — Interpret

Why does the official need assistance? What does Philip do with the passage? What does this event teach about the relationship between reading and understanding?

Step 5 — Apply

Only after establishing the passage's meaning, ask what legitimate principle concerning biblical interpretation can be learned from this event.

Reflection and Review

Before moving to Lesson 2, you should be able to explain the difference between hermeneutics and exegesis, distinguish exegesis from eisegesis, explain why meaning must precede application, and describe the relationship among observation, interpretation, and application.

SCRIPTURE STANDS OVER THE INTERPRETER AS THE AUTHORITY.

Lesson Summary

define biblical hermeneutics;

explain the relationship between hermeneutics and exegesis;

distinguish exegesis from eisegesis;

recognize that Scripture communicates meaning that the interpreter seeks to discover rather than create;

explain why observation precedes interpretation and interpretation precedes application;

identify the importance of context, speaker, and audience;

distinguish description from automatic prescription; and

approach Scripture with the conviction that the biblical text—not the interpreter's preferred conclusion—governs interpretation.

Progressive Glossary

Hermeneutics — The disciplined study and application of principles used to understand the meaning of Scripture faithfully.

Exegesis — The careful examination of a biblical text in order to draw out the meaning established by the text.

Eisegesis — Reading an idea or meaning into a passage that the passage itself does not establish.

Observation — Careful attention to what the biblical text actually says before determining its meaning.

Interpretation — The process of determining the meaning communicated by a biblical text.

Application — The legitimate response or implication that follows from properly established biblical meaning.

Context — The surrounding linguistic, literary, historical, and communicative setting that helps determine the meaning of a passage.

Description — A biblical report of what occurred.

Prescription — An instruction or obligation established by the text.

Direct Governing Authority — Authority Scripture establishes as directly obligating an identified audience under the relevant divine assignment. **Profitable Instruction** — The legitimate doctrinal, corrective, historical, theological, warning, wisdom, or principled value of inspired Scripture even where an original command or obligation does not directly transfer to a later reader.

Historical Participation — Involvement in a biblical event or practice; participation itself does not establish continuing doctrinal obligation. **Programmatic Ownership** — The relationship by which Scriptural evidence identifies a message, command, commission, or ministry as belonging under a particular divine assignment.

Classification Confidence — The degree to which the available Scriptural evidence warrants a proposed classification: explicit, strongly supported, probable, possible, or undetermined.

Undetermined Classification — A responsible conclusion that available evidence is insufficient for final programmatic classification and that additional Scriptural investigation is required.

Eight-Control Classification Test — The analytical method examining speaker, audience, revelatory source, programmatic authority, purpose, historical setting, immediate context, and application before assigning programmatic classification.

LESSON 31 — PRESUPPOSITIONS AND INTERPRETIVE SYSTEMS

Recognizing the Assumptions Readers Bring to Scripture

Lesson Purpose

This lesson trains the reader to identify presuppositions without pretending that interpretation can occur from a position of complete neutrality. Every interpreter brings convictions about Scripture, language, history, theology, and the relationship of biblical passages. The responsible task is to make those convictions visible and testable rather than allowing them to govern silently.

Readers will distinguish a presupposition from an observation, an interpretive rule from a theological conclusion, and a useful framework from a controlling assumption. They will learn how systems can organize evidence well while still being capable of circular reasoning, selective attention, or conclusions stronger than the passages support.

By the end of the lesson, students will be able to identify their starting assumptions, explain how those assumptions influence questions and classifications, and submit every interpretive model to passage-level and cumulative biblical testing.

Biblical Foundation

Read Acts 17:10–12; Luke 24:25–27; 2 Timothy 2:15; 2 Timothy 3:14–17; and 2 Peter 3:15–18.

Observe the responsibilities placed upon readers, teachers, and hearers.

A framework may help the reader ask disciplined questions. It may not supply answers that the passage has not established.

Teaching Development

1. Presuppositions Are Unavoidable but Testable

The goal is not to claim freedom from all assumptions. The goal is to distinguish warranted commitments from unexamined habits and to expose both to correction by Scripture.

2. Method and Model Are Not Identical

A method describes how evidence will be gathered and evaluated. A model organizes conclusions reached through that method. A model must therefore remain revisable when new or contrary evidence is established.

3. Questions May Guide Without Predetermining

Audience, covenant, chronology, genre, and revelatory setting are legitimate questions. They become distortions when the interpreter assumes the answer before examining the text.

4. Circular Reasoning Must Be Exposed

An argument is circular when a model proves the interpretation and the interpretation is then offered as proof of the model without independent textual support.

5. Fair Testing Includes Counterevidence

A responsible interpreter records passages that appear to resist the preferred conclusion and explains them without caricature, dismissal, or special pleading.

6. Sources of Presuppositions

Presuppositions arise from more than formal theology. Church tradition, translation choices, familiar preaching, personal experience, cultural assumptions, and the order in which passages were first learned can all influence interpretation. Some assumptions are consciously affirmed; others operate as unexamined expectations about what a passage must say.

The interpreter should therefore ask two questions. What convictions properly follow from Scripture as a whole? What expectations have been imported from habit or community without adequate testing? The first question preserves theological responsibility. The second creates room for correction.

7. Three Ways a Framework Can Function

A framework may function heuristically by helping the reader notice relevant questions. It may function descriptively by organizing conclusions already established. It may function prescriptively by deciding in advance which conclusions are allowed. The first two uses can assist interpretation; the third risks circularity when the framework is insulated from textual correction.

A framework is strongest when it explains why its questions matter, identifies which claims are explicit and which are inferential, and acknowledges passages that remain difficult. Its usefulness decreases when every passage is made to confirm the framework regardless of context.

8. Strengths and Limitations of Systematic Reading

Systematic reading helps the interpreter relate passages, maintain consistency, remember the whole canon, and avoid conclusions that contradict clear teaching elsewhere. It is especially valuable when a doctrine depends upon cumulative evidence rather than a single verse.

Its limitation is the temptation to flatten diversity of genre, audience, terminology, or historical setting. Systematic coherence is not a substitute for passage-level exegesis. A coherent model can still be wrong if its premises are selective or its classifications are assumed.

9. Worked Example — The Meaning of Church

Suppose a reader begins with the assumption that every occurrence of the word church refers to precisely the same corporate group. Another reader assumes that every occurrence must refer to a different group unless identity is independently proved. Both assumptions can distort the inquiry.

A disciplined study first observes how the word functions in each passage, identifies the audience and historical setting, distinguishes ordinary assembly language from theological identity claims, and only then correlates the passages. The example demonstrates that neither automatic identity nor automatic distinction may replace contextual evidence.

10. Presupposition Audit Procedure

Before defending an interpretation, write the proposed conclusion, the passages believed to support it, the assumptions required to connect those passages, and the evidence that would count against the conclusion. Then identify whether the reasoning depends upon an explicit statement, a cumulative pattern, an analogy, or a model-level inference.

This procedure does not eliminate conviction. It makes conviction accountable. The result may confirm the original view, qualify it, replace it, or leave the issue unresolved.

Common Errors

Common errors include denying that one has presuppositions, treating inherited terminology as though Scripture defined it identically, confusing familiarity with proof, and applying severe scrutiny only to competing views. Another error is endless self-questioning that never permits a conclusion. Interpretive humility requires corrigibility, not permanent indecision.

Guided Practice

Exercise 1 — Write three theological assumptions you bring to a disputed passage. For each, state what evidence could confirm, qualify, or overturn it.

Exercise 2 — Compare two interpretations of the same passage. Separate shared observations, disputed inferences, and system-level conclusions.

Exercise 3 — Rewrite a circular argument so that each conclusion rests upon independently examined evidence.

KNOW — Synthesize the course controls governing observation, context, language, literary form, canonical correlation, doctrine, programmatic assignment, and application.

IDENTIFY — Select the controls materially required by an unfamiliar passage and classify the evidence as explicit, strongly supported, probable, possible, or unresolved.

DIAGNOSE — Audit an interpretation for contextual, lexical, grammatical, canonical, doctrinal, chronological, programmatic, and application errors, including counterevidence it neglects.

PERFORM — Complete and defend an independent exegesis that follows Meaning first. Assignment second. Application third., maintains an evidence ledger, addresses a serious competing interpretation, and states interpretive boundaries.

STUDENT TOOLS

TOOL 1 — EVIDENCE LEDGER

The evidence ledger records the reasoning between the biblical passage and the interpretive conclusion. Its purpose is not to create paperwork; it is to make evidence, inference, uncertainty, and correction visible. Use it whenever a lesson asks you to establish a substantial interpretation, doctrinal claim, programmatic classification, or application.

What the Ledger Must Preserve

- Passage before claim — record the unit of Scripture actually being interpreted.
- Observation before inference — distinguish what the passage explicitly supplies from what reasoning adds.
- Context before correlation — establish the passage in its own setting before bringing in another passage.
- Meaning before assignment — determine what the passage communicates before classifying its governing audience or programmatic authority.
- Assignment before application — identify direct governing authority before proposing present response.
- Counterevidence before confidence — test the preferred reading against evidence that may qualify or overturn it.

Evidence and Confidence Scale

Classification	Use
Explicit	Scripture directly states the conclusion.

Classification	Use
Strongly supported	Multiple substantial lines of evidence converge on the conclusion.
Probable	The conclusion best accounts for the evidence, though material uncertainty remains.
Possible	The conclusion is compatible with the evidence but cannot be established confidently.
Unresolved	Available evidence does not justify a responsible conclusion.

Short-Form Evidence Ledger

Use one row for each major claim. Add rows as needed. If the claim cannot be supported within the row, complete the full-entry worksheet that follows.

Claim	Passage	Evidence	Control / Lens	Assignment	Confidence

FULL EVIDENCE-LEDGER ENTRY

Complete one full entry for every conclusion that materially affects the interpretation. Write concisely, but supply enough information for another reader to test the reasoning.

1. Passage or interpretive unit Record the book, chapter, verses, and the larger unit needed for context.	
2. Interpretive question State the question the evidence must answer.	
3. Proposed claim State one testable conclusion—not several conclusions joined together.	
4. Direct textual evidence Record decisive words, relationships, structure, grammar, argument, or explicit explanation.	

5. Observation or inference? Identify what is explicit and what depends upon reasoning. Explain the inferential step.	
6. Communication setting Identify speaker or writer, audience, occasion, purpose, and relevant historical setting.	
7. Literary and linguistic controls Record genre, figures, syntax, word meaning, or structural features that materially affect meaning.	
8. Canonical correlation Identify related passages only after interpreting this passage. Classify the relationship and preserve progressive revelation.	
9. Meaning State what the passage communicates in its own context.	
10. Programmatic assignment Identify audience, authority, chronology, and divine program from the evidence. Do not classify merely by speaker.	
11. Application category Select: Direct governing; Principled; Historical/doctrinal; or Illegitimate programmatic transfer.	
12. Counterevidence or competing reading State the strongest material challenge fairly and explain its effect on the claim.	
13. Confidence and boundary Classify confidence and state what the passage does not establish.	
14. Revision or next investigation Record how the claim should change or what evidence must be investigated next.	

Ledger Audit Before Submission

- ☐ Can another reader locate every passage and follow every inferential step?
- ☐ Did the passage establish the meaning before the framework classified it?
- ☐ Did programmatic assignment arise from audience, content, authority, and chronology rather than from the speaker alone?
- ☐ Did the application remain subordinate to meaning and assignment?
- ☐ Did counterevidence affect the final confidence level where appropriate?
- ☐ Is the final claim stated no more strongly than the evidence warrants?

TOOL 2 — SEVEN LENSES DIAGNOSTIC WORKSHEET

The Seven Lenses help the reader classify a passage, ministry, practice, audience, or doctrinal claim without allowing one attractive feature to control the entire conclusion. The lenses organize investigation; Scripture supplies the evidence. Use this tool after establishing the passage's immediate meaning and before making a final programmatic assignment.

MASTER CONTROL: RUN ALL SEVEN LENSES. NO SINGLE LENS—including AUDIENCE, CHRONOLOGY, APOSTOLIC PERFORMER, OR SIGNS—is INDEPENDENTLY DECISIVE.

Required Diagnostic Discipline

- Record direct textual observations before framework inferences.
- Distinguish the person performing an action from the authority and commission under which the action occurs.
- Disaggregate mixed audiences; do not average everyone present into one programmatic identity.
- In Acts, test every proposed chronological relationship from the narrative evidence and later inspired explanation.
- Where evidence remains incomplete or mixed, record a qualified or unresolved diagnosis rather than forcing certainty.

Seven Lenses Reference

Lens	Function	Diagnostic Question	Guardrail
1. Audience	Identify the immediate audience and the setting in which that audience appears: Israelward, Gentileward, mixed, or an identifiable assembly/community.	Who is directly addressed? Who is merely present? What other lenses corroborate or complicate the audience evidence?	Ethnicity, physical presence, or the word church does not independently establish program identity.
2. Apostolic Authority	Identify the apostolic authority governing the passage. The Twelve exercise Prophecy apostleship under the Kingdom Commission; Paul exercises his distinct apostleship under the Pauline Commission received from the risen Christ.	Whose authority is operative? Is the source of authority being distinguished from the field in which ministry occurs?	Paul may minister in an Israelward setting without becoming a Kingdom apostle or inheriting the Twelve's commission.
3. Covenant	Determine whether the passage explicitly invokes or clearly presupposes Israel's covenants, covenant promises, or covenant identity.	Which covenant markers are present, and what does the passage actually connect to them?	The Body of Christ is not constituted by incorporation into Israel's covenants. Absence of covenant language is not independently decisive.

Lens	Function	Diagnostic Question	Guardrail
4. Sign-Authentication	Determine whether signs, wonders, or miracles occur and what function the passage assigns to them. Do not infer a complete audience, chronology, or governing assignment from the presence of a sign alone.	Is a sign present? What message, authority, audience, or divine purpose does the context associate with it?	Signs through Paul do not make him a Kingdom apostle. Presence or absence of a sign cannot classify the passage by itself.
5. Commission	Distinguish the Twelve's Kingdom Commission from Paul's Pauline Commission. Paul's risen-Christ commission includes Gentiles, kings, and Israel but remains his own distinct commission.	What commission governs the ministry or instruction described? What textual evidence establishes that conclusion?	Do not confuse an Israelward ministry setting with possession of the Kingdom Commission.
6. Eschatology	Identify the future hope, destiny, or consummation in view. Establish recipients, promises, covenantal setting, and canonical development before assigning a theological category.	What future hope is described, to whom does it belong, and through which revelatory program is it made known?	Shared terminology or shared redemption in Christ does not erase distinct corporate identities and destinies.
7. Dispensational Setting	Integrate the other lenses to identify the passage's audience, authority, commission, revelatory setting, and governing assignment, or state that the conclusion remains qualified or unresolved.	What combined pattern of audience, authority, covenant, sign, commission, and eschatology best accounts for the passage?	Chronology alone does not determine theological identity or governing assignment. No conclusion may exceed the evidence supplied by audience, context, authority, commission, and revelatory setting.

SEVEN LENSES — PASSAGE WORKSHEET

Passage / unit Book, chapter, verses, and surrounding unit	
Interpretive question The specific question being tested	
Immediate meaning What the passage communicates before programmatic classification	
Initial hypothesis A provisional classification to test—not a conclusion to protect	

Lens-by-Lens Evidence Record

Lens	Direct Observation	Inference / Significance	Assessment
1. Audience Who is directly addressed? Who is merely present? What other lenses corroborate or complicate the audience evidence?			Supports Prophecy / Supports Mystery / Mixed / Neutral / Unresolved
2. Apostolic Authority Whose authority is operative? Is the source of authority being distinguished from the field in which ministry occurs?			Supports Prophecy / Supports Mystery / Mixed / Neutral / Unresolved
3. Covenant Which covenant markers are present, and what does the passage actually connect to them?			Supports Prophecy / Supports Mystery / Mixed / Neutral / Unresolved
4. Sign-Authentication Is a sign present? What message, authority, audience, or divine purpose does the context associate with it?			Supports Prophecy / Supports Mystery / Mixed / Neutral / Unresolved
5. Commission What commission governs the ministry or instruction described? What textual evidence establishes that conclusion?			Supports Prophecy / Supports Mystery / Mixed / Neutral / Unresolved

Lens	Direct Observation	Inference / Significance	Assessment
6. Eschatology What future hope is described, to whom does it belong, and through which revelatory program is it made known?			Supports Prophecy / Supports Mystery / Mixed / Neutral / Unresolved
7. Dispensational Setting What combined pattern of audience, authority, covenant, sign, commission, and eschatology best accounts for the passage?			Supports Prophecy / Supports Mystery / Mixed / Neutral / Unresolved

SEVEN LENSES — INTEGRATED DIAGNOSIS

A final diagnosis must account for the entire evidence pattern. Do not count lenses mechanically. Weigh the clarity, relevance, and contextual force of the evidence each lens supplies.

Strongest direct evidence Which observation carries the greatest interpretive weight, and why?	
Corroborating evidence Which additional lenses materially support the reading?	
Complicating or counterevidence Which evidence resists, qualifies, or limits the preferred diagnosis?	
Mixed-audience or cross-field factors Who is addressed, who is present, and under whose authority and commission does the ministry occur?	
Chronological location Before Acts 9; Acts 9–28; at the Acts 28 boundary; or beyond Acts 28. Explain what chronology establishes and what it does not.	
Assignment diagnosis Primary audience or assignment / Mixed or disputed setting / Qualified / Unresolved	
Confidence Explicit / Strongly supported / Probable / Possible / Unresolved	

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